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Her Excellency the Honourable Ms Sam Mostyn AC
Governor-General of the Commonwealth of Australia

Your Excellency,

Thank you so much for the kind opportunity to represent Australia's Buddhist community for the "Connecting Communities through unity, inclusion, and care" event at Admiralty House, Kirribilli, on Monday 19 January. My apologies, but I shall not accept the invitation. If I may take a few words to explain why, speaking purely from my personal perspective, and not on behalf of any Australian Buddhist organizations.

For over twenty years, I have in all good faith served the Buddhist community through cultivating healthy relationships with other faiths. I have had countless positive experiences, but others that have made me question the purpose of this work.

- On one occasion, a government minister and religious leaders discussed how to deprive women of reproductive rights. A Buddhist nun was the only woman present and she was ignored.
- On another occasion, I asked how we could ensure better female representation in religious matters. The government minister dismissed the suggestion, pointing out that even his own party was highly unequal. No-one supported me. Again, Buddhist nuns were among the very few women present.
- At yet another event, when an Indian woman asked when we would see better female representation in religious leadership, a bishop said, "Not any time soon".
- After ASIO had identified extreme right terrorists as Australia's most urgent security threat, a government minister spoke to religious leaders of "extremists left and right", naming environmentalists as a threat comparable to the extreme right. I had been at a climate change rally the previous day, and have participated in faith-based climate action for many years.
- One event turned out, to my surprise, to be stoking moral panic about young people's sexuality. I was the only religious representative who stood up for sexual inclusion and acceptance.
- At yet another event, an interfaith visit to China was proposed. I canvassed the Buddhist community, and was told by Australia's Tibetan Buddhists that they welcomed engagement with the Chinese government. Nonetheless, the Christian organizer canceled the event, citing to the Chinese government its treatment of Tibetans, overriding the explicit request of Australia's Tibetan community.
- At a multicultural review, I pointed out that the management was overwhelmingly dominated by Muslims and asked for Buddhist representation. Though I was supported by the Christian, Indigenous, and Hindu representatives present, my request was refused.
- At a discussion over a proposed human rights bill for Australia, I witnessed politicians and bishops united in their opposition to guarantees of human rights for all.

- At a recent service following the Bondi massacre, when Sydney's religious representatives were invited to light Hanukkah candles, the Israeli ambassador was invited alongside them, creating a politically-charged context that I for one was deeply uncomfortable with.

At none of these events did I feel that my voice was listened to or my views welcome. And I am well aware that as a white, able-bodied, Australian-born, native English-speaking male, my own experience will be better than many others.

I deeply believe in the dignity of all people, and the requirement of religious service to call us to a higher love. In this, I believe that my fellow religious leaders would agree.

Yet when I look into what they say, too often I see senior religious leaders treat people of different sexual desire as intrinsically sinful or disordered. They speak of equality, but maintain absolutist power structures that deny women's voices and agency over their own bodies. They speak of the divine nature of all human beings, but refuse to accept the reality of people whose gender identity does not fit into the simple binary of their ancient scriptures. They evoke the beauty of creation, while discounting climate science and disparaging those who seek to preserve the integrity of the environment. They think it natural that they should police the sexuality of others, while evading responsibility for systematic child abuse in their own institutions. They speak of peace and endorse genocide.

Everyone condemns discrimination and injustice, except when it comes to their own specific case. Then they argue that their scripture, their tradition, their religion demands that an exception be carved out for themselves. When bigotry is sanctioned by appeal to divine authority, it is a step on a road that leads to one end only: the elimination of undesirable populations.

We see this happening today among our brothers and sisters in the United States. Years of unfettered, extremist religious bigotry have led to a state where fundamental principles of justice are being torn up and discarded with impunity by zealots possessed of unshakable faith that they are doing God's will. And when people of genuine religious integrity, including men and women of the cloth, speak up for justice, or stand beside the vulnerable, they too are crushed beneath the boot.

When I discussed with a Buddhist community about attending an event on religious harmony, a common sentiment was that it is religion that leads to disharmony, since it creates in-groups and out-groups where one is inherently better than the other. I disagreed with this, as I believe that a true religious calling expands the scope of our moral compass and leads us to a deeper and broader love for all beings. I have joyfully celebrated with my fellow religious practitioners of all faiths on many occasions, and been inspired by their sincerity and pure aspiration. Nonetheless, as with the examples given above, I have too often felt that my presence served merely as an enrobed endorsement of values I do not share.

The Buddha spoke often of the importance of harmony. For him, harmony manifests in the presence of truth, of equality, and of fairness and justice before the law. Sadly, this has often not been the case for me in interfaith contexts in Australia. I hope you understand how my experience has led me to the point where I can no longer trust that religious or political leaders are engaging with me or my community in anything other than a tokenistic manner.

yours sincerely,

Bhante Sujato

13/1/2026